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APPS



**Jack Dorsey's Bluetooth
messaging app Bitchat
now on App Store**



[Bitchat](#), a messaging app created by Twitter and Block founder Jack Dorsey, is available to download from the [iOS App Store](#). Dorsey says he coded the basis of the app over the course of a weekend in early July.

Bitchat operates through Bluetooth mesh networks, which means that users can send messages to others within the range of Bluetooth connectivity — usually around 100 meters — without cell reception or a Wi-Fi connection.

The app's UX is very minimal. There is no log-in system, and you're immediately brought to an instant messaging box, where you can see what nearby users are saying (if anyone is actually around you and using the app) and set your display name, which can be changed at any time.

While Bitchat is sparking interest due to Dorsey's reputation, the concept of Bluetooth-powered messaging apps is not new. These apps are also popular in settings like large music festivals, where cell service may be limited, or in the aftermath of natural disasters, where cell service and Wi-Fi availability may be impacted. The Bluetooth messaging app [Bridgefy](#) was notably used during pro-democracy [protests](#) in Hong Kong, since its ability to function without the internet made it harder for authorities to detect.

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Dorsey advertised Bitchat as a secure, private messaging platform when it went live for beta use earlier this month. But security researcher Alex Radocea [pointed out in a blog post](#) that it's easy to impersonate other people within Bitchat, calling into question how secure the "[vibe-coded](#)" app really is.

"In cryptography, details matter," Radocea wrote. "A protocol that has the right vibes can have fundamental substance flaws that compromise everything it claims to protect."

Dorsey later admitted that the software had [not been subject to an external security review](#) and thus may contain vulnerabilities.

Bitchat's concerns around impersonation also extend to the app itself. As of now, the app can be downloaded for iOS via the App Store, or it can be loaded onto an Android device by [downloading the app from GitHub](#). However, the Google Play store hosts multiple apps that appear to be pretending to be Dorsey's app, which have garnered thousands of downloads.

Dorsey has not directly addressed the fake Bitchat apps on the Google Play store, but he did repost [another user's X post](#) that said that Bitchat is not yet on Google Play, and to "beware of fakes."

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Amanda Silberling

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Amanda Silberling is a senior writer at TechCrunch covering the intersection of technology and culture. She...



IMAGE CREDITS: TEAONHER (MODIFIED)

SECURITY



TeaOnHer, a rival Tea app for men, is leaking users' personal data and driver's licenses

Amanda Silberling, Zack Whittaker

12:40 PM PDT · August 6, 2025

TeaOnHer, an app designed for men to share photos and information about women they have supposedly dated, has exposed users' personal information, including government IDs and selfies, TechCrunch can confirm.

The app, which launched on the Apple App Store earlier this week, is a response to another viral app Tea that allows women to post about the men they

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date. Tea is advertised as a women’s safety app with more than 6 million users that is similar to “[Are we dating the same guy?](#)” Facebook networks. However, the app is controversial, since many of the claims that women post cannot be verified.

The backlash surrounding Tea escalated last week, after 404 Media reported 4chan users retaliated by [discovering a publicly exposed database](#) belonging to the app, which [revealed](#) over 72,000 images, including thousands of selfies and photo IDs submitted for account verification. A [subsequent hack](#) exposed more than 1 million private messages sent over the app, prompting the app to [disable](#) its messaging feature.

TeaOnHer, which is now ranked No. 2 among Lifestyle apps on iOS, appears to be a direct rebuttal to the Tea app, even copying the language from Tea’s App Store description in its own listing.

But like the app it sought to emulate, TeaOnHer contains security flaws of its own.

TechCrunch has found at least one security flaw that allows anyone access to data belonging to TeaOnHer app users, including their usernames and associated email addresses, as well as driver’s licenses and selfies that users uploaded to TeaOnHer. Images of these driver’s licenses are publicly accessible web addresses, allowing anyone with the links to access them using their web browser.

In one case, TechCrunch saw a list of posts shared on TeaOnHer appended with each user’s email address, display name, and self-reported location.

TechCrunch is withholding some of the details of the bugs so as to not help malicious actors access anyone’s data. The app’s maker did not respond to emails from TechCrunch asking who we can report

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the flaws to. As such, TechCrunch is publishing this report with limited details of the issue, given the app's current popularity and the risk faced with using the app.

TeaOnHer was uploaded to the iOS App Store by a developer named Newville Media Corporation. According to LinkedIn, the founder and CEO of this company is Xavier Lampkin.

TechCrunch identified at least one TeaOnHer record associated with Lampkin's own data.

The security lapse will likely affect any user who signed up or shared identity documents with the app. The bug also exposes the number of users the TeaOnHer app has, which is about 53,000 users at the time of publication.

TechCrunch also identified a potential second security issue, in which an email address and plaintext password belonging to the app's creator, Lampkin, was left exposed on the server. The credentials appear to grant access to the app's "admin" panel. TechCrunch did not use the credentials, as doing so would be unlawful, but highlights the risks of inadvertently leaving admin credentials exposed to the web.

Along with its security flaws, the content portrayed within TeaOnHer is troubling in itself. While the app requests IDs and selfies from its users to verify their identities — a process that is not automatic — users can access a "guest" view of the app without signing in.

Immediately upon opening "guest" view, TechCrunch saw several images of the same naked woman, posted under different names in a form of spam. It is not clear if this woman consented to this photo being shared. Other posts share the photos and names of women, alongside comments calling

them “easy,” or accusing them of spreading sexually transmitted infections.

Across all free apps, TeaOnHer is ranked No. 17, higher than apps like Instagram, Netflix, Uber, and Spotify. Tea is currently ranked No. 2.

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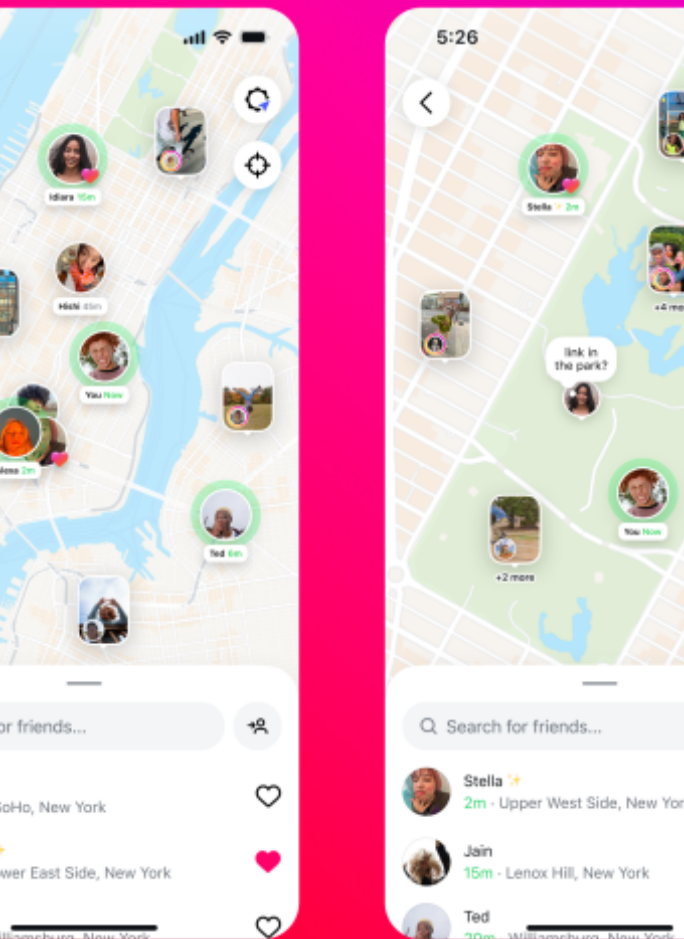


IMAGE CREDITS: INSTAGRAM

APPS



Instagram takes on Snapchat with new 'Instagram Map'

Aisha Malik — 7:00 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

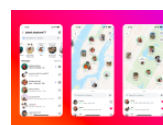
Instagram is rolling out Instagram Map, a new feature that lets users share their most recent active location with others and discover location-based content. The Meta-owned social network is also launching reposts, and making its “Friends” tab in Reels available globally.

With its new map feature, Instagram is copying yet another popular feature from Snapchat, after cloning the app’s core Stories functionality [back in 2016](#). Instagram is coming for Snap Map’s crown, a feature that recently surpassed 400 million

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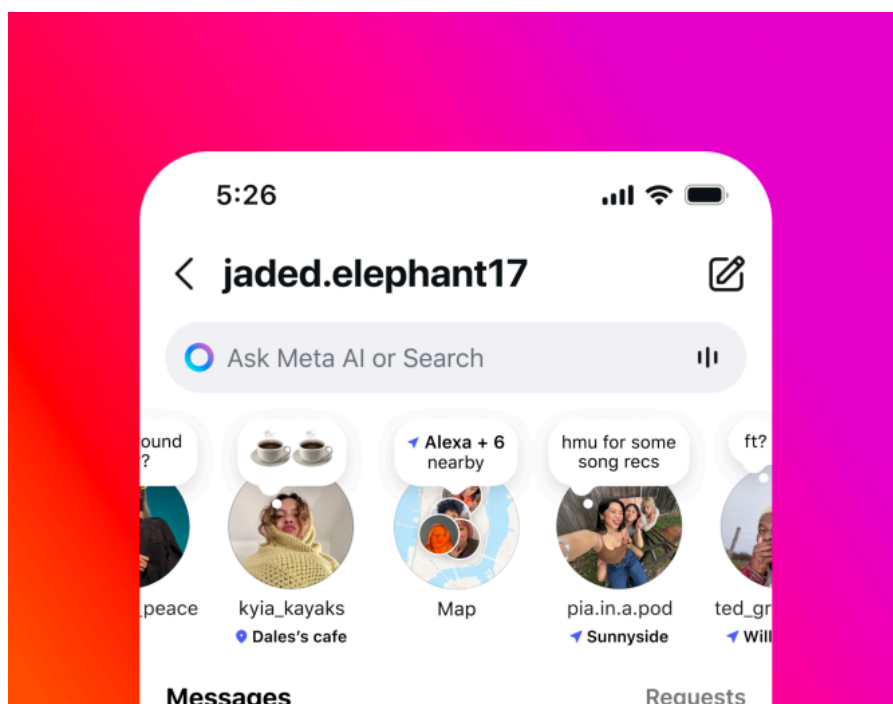
How to use Instagram Map and set your location-sharing preferences

Aisha Malik - 9 hours ago

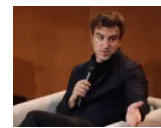
monthly active users and remains one of the app's core offerings.

Instagram notes that location sharing is off by default on Instagram Map, and a user's location only updates when they open the app, meaning it doesn't provide real-time location updates. Snap Map, on the other hand, allows users to choose whether their location is updated only when they open the app or in real time.

It's worth noting that Instagram does offer [real-time location sharing via DMs](#) (direct messages). However, unlike Apple's Find My and Snap Map, which let you share your location with others indefinitely, Instagram only lets users do so for up to one hour.



AI



AI agents aren't the 'new Google,' says Airbnb CEO

Sarah Perez - 13 hours ago

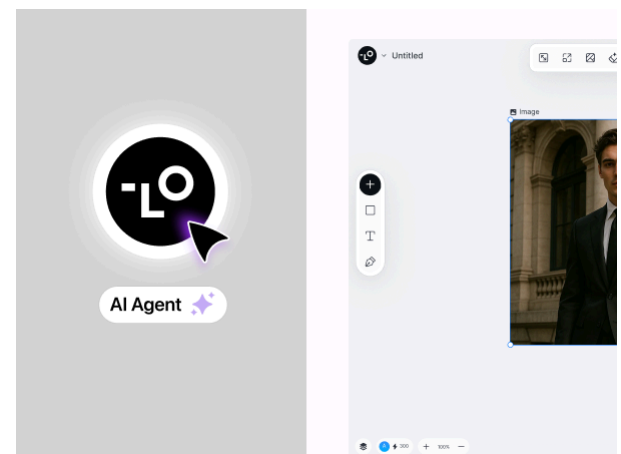
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The backlash against Duolingo going 'AI-first' didn't even matter

Amanda Silberling
- 13 hours ago

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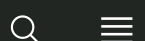
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city, you'll be able to discover it on Instagram Map.

Regardless of whether you choose to share your location, you can use the map to explore location-based content, Instagram says.

The map also allows users to leave short messages, or [“Notes,”](#) on the map for others to see. Instagram Notes are currently the short messages that appear at the top of your direct messaging feed, but with the launch of Instagram Map, users can now post these short updates on the map.

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Although Instagram is certainly taking on Snapchat with this new feature, it also has the opportunity to appeal to people who were fans of [Zenly](#), a social map app that Snap acquired and then shut down in 2023.

The new map feature is launching in the United States starting Wednesday, with broader global availability coming soon. Users can find the Instagram Map at the top of their DM inbox.

The launch doesn't come as a surprise, as [Instagram was spotted developing](#) the map feature last year.



IMAGE CREDITS: INSTAGRAM

As for the new “Reposts” feature, Instagram is taking a page out of [TikTok’s book](#) while also creating its own version of the popular “retweet” function from Twitter (now X).

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This feature lets Instagram users repost public reels and feed posts. These reposts may show up in their friends' feeds and will also be displayed in a new "Reposts" tab on their profile. Instagram says the new feature gives users a way to share their interests with others and also offers creators the opportunity to reach a wider audience.

To repost a reel or post, users tap the repost icon. Users can also choose to add a note to the repost by typing into the thought bubble that appears on screen and pressing save.

Regarding the new "Friends" tab in Reels, Instagram launched it in the United States earlier this year and is now making it available globally. The tab lets you see public reels that your friends have liked, commented on, reposted, and created.

For users who want to browse and interact with content privately, Instagram is rolling out the ability to opt out of having content you've engaged with shown in the friends tab.

Users can hide their likes, comments, and reposts from the tab. Additionally, they can choose to mute likes, comments, and reposts from specific people they follow.

Topics: [Apps](#) [Instagram](#) [instagram map](#) [Snap Map](#)

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Aisha Malik

Consumer News Reporter |

Aisha is a consumer news reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining the publication in 2021, she was a telecom reporte...



IMAGE CREDITS: LOCKET

SOCIAL



Photo-sharing app Locket is banking on a new celebrity-focused feature to fuel its growth

Lauren Forristal — 6:00 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

[Locket](#), the photo-sharing app that allows users to share images with friends that are then displayed on their home screens as widgets, wants to stay on your radar, and it's enlisting the help of celebrities.

When it launched in 2022, Locket emerged as a competitor to BeReal, offering a more authentic way to connect with others. The app places a widget on iPhone home screens that updates with

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the latest pictures added by friends. Users can select up to 20 close friends, creating an intimate space to share unfiltered selfies and updates on their lives.

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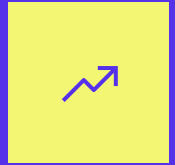
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The app claims to have over 80 million total downloads and more than 9 million daily active users, and its users have shared more than 10 billion photos to date. Notably, the company also shared with TechCrunch that it achieved profitability in 2024, a significant accomplishment given its relatively modest fundraising efforts of just [\\$12.5 million](#).

To drive additional growth, Locket has been quietly testing a feature called “Celebrity Lockets” for the past six months, which the app officially announced on Wednesday.

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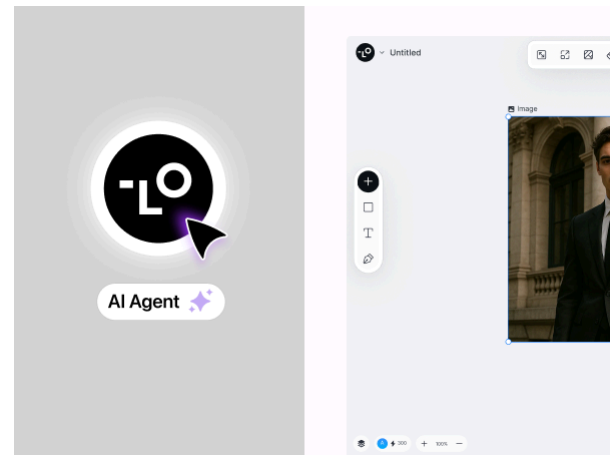
IMAGE CREDITS: LOCKET

Celebrity Lockets mostly focuses on music artists, letting them engage with fans by sharing details about upcoming shows, new album releases, and other news. Locket has already tested this feature with [Suki Waterhouse](#) and [JVKE](#), with more artists to be announced soon.

To use the feature, celebrities can share a link on their social media platforms, or fans can look them up in the app to add them, and they can then send photos directly to their fans' home screens.

“With posts going straight to fans’ home screens, it offers the kind of immediacy and intimacy that

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other platforms can't replicate, turning passive followers into active participants," founder Matt Moss told TechCrunch.

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Locket allows artists to choose a number of fans to connect with, ranging from 1,000 to 15,000 slots. For instance, Suki has 5,000 fans on the app and has helped Locket attract hundreds of new members. According to the company, 17% of these 5,000 fans were new to Locket.

“Fans feel special knowing they’re one of just a few thousand rather than just another follower. This also preserves the same intimacy and brand of Locket as a product today ... We knew our community used Locket to share music with their friends, so being able to also connect with their favorite artists is a natural evolution for the platform,” Moss said.

Although Moss says the feedback from testers has been good, it’s unclear whether this will help Locket grow its user numbers. BeReal tried something similar with a feature called “[RealPeople](#),” but the reception wasn’t entirely positive, with [some people](#) saying that they preferred the anti-social media app as a way to escape from celebrities.

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Lauren Forristal



Lauren covers media, streaming, apps and platforms at TechCrunch....

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